

Age of the Alpha Woman

They curse, get drunk, do stunts, and oh my God, even come on to boys. Meet popular culture's sassy new Hunterwali heroines.

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Anita Hassanandani takes a deep breath, says *Jai Mata Di*, and dives from a 12-storey building. Yana Gupta smiles while a creepy crawly walks over her face. Pooja Bedi remembers her children before diving into ice cold water. In Colors' new *Khatron ke Khiladi* (with an average first six-day TRP of 1.53), Akshay Kumar may be the star, wearing a singlet and knee-high trousers, but it's the women who are walking away with the wows. The role reversal is everywhere. In *Ugly Aur Pagli*, a film distinguished by its idea (borrowed from a Korean film) rather than its execution, Ranvir Shorey is a slacker, having outlived his engineering school by four years. Mallika Sherawat is a woman who snores, swears, slaps and swills several drinks. Whether it's a dare (will she wear her innerwear as pouterwear) or armwrestling, Sherawat wins every gender bending battle. In *MTV Splitsvilla* (TRP of 0.70), a show where 20 girls ostensibly compete for the attention of two boys, the girls show exactly what it takes to be the empowered new alpha woman. If Bianca Mendonca says the sexiest part of her body is her tongue, then another contestant Minakshi Khanduri thinks nothing of

dedicating a poem to herself.

Whether it's a mud fight between Bosky Bhatia and Prianka Sharma or an expletive-filled exchange between Hannah Sim and Yamini Batra, nothing gets in the way of the girls and their prize—not the man but the opportunity to host a show with him. "Our women have always been feisty," says Ashish Patil, general manager, MTV. So explosive are some situations—the format requires the women to exhibit their

various talents, among them how to wear a swimsuit as much as how to go on a date—that MTV is unable to air them. The air is so thick with abuse.

It was the same in Channel V's modelling show, *Get Gorgeous 5*, whose finale saw the girls indulging in bitchfests and backstabbing sessions. Nothing is off-limits anymore in what appears to be the Rakhi Sawant-isation of women on television. And it's making pop culture's creators finally understand the truth: that alpha women matter. Take a look at television ads—from the TVS commercial where a young woman coaxes a boastful boy into declaring he cannot play tennis to the HDFC Standard Life Insurance ad where a young woman pays for her father's car to the tune of *sar uthake jiyo*.

In the global age of the alpha women, where *Juno*-esque girls meets *Superbad* slacker boys, several rules are being rewritten. Women can and do draw a line in the sand and ask others to follow. Take Sherawat off-screen—whether it is registering her name as a trademark or refusing to appear on

Ugly Aur Pagli

Mallika Sherawat plays the hero in high heels, whose trademark dare to her man is *marna hai kya* (do you want to die?). The slaps are fun but the story flounders.

"The film is about a 21st century girl who is more aggressive and dominating."

Sachin Khot, Director

ALPHA WOMAN QUOTIENT



High



Medium



Low

